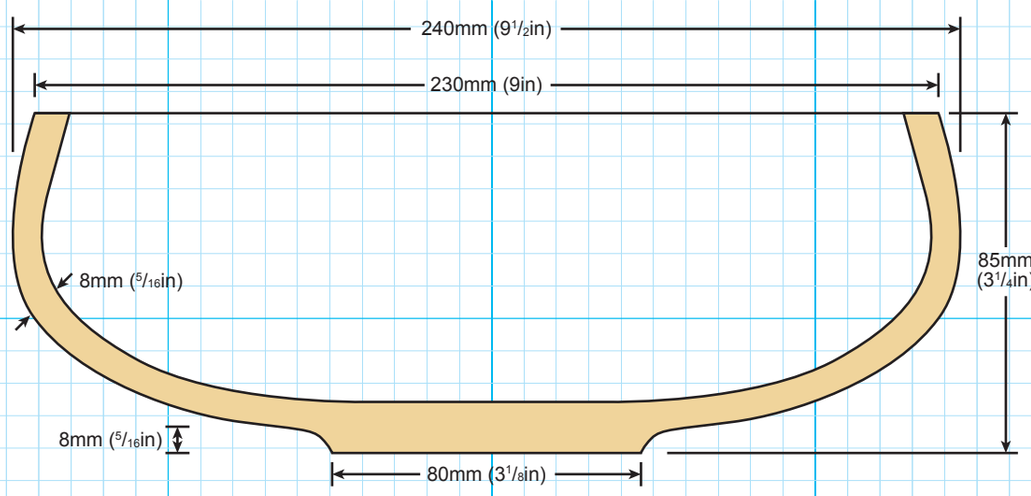
PLANS AND EQUIPMENT

EQUIPMENT USED

Abrasives	Four-jaw chuck	Hacksaw
PVA adhesive	Forstner bit	Power sanding disc
Bandsaw	LED lamp	Buffing system
Steb centre	Mini hollowing tool	
13mm bowl gouge	3mm parting tool	



If at first you don't succeed...

I have a confession to make. Despite almost 40 years of woodturning, I had not, before this, turned a piece of horse chestnut. I'd read that the wood was fairly plain, soft and easy to turn. My plan here was to turn a reasonably straightforward bowl. What could possibly go wrong?

1 I began by purchasing a good-sized bowl blank about 250 x 100mm. It appeared to be a nice clean piece with no knots, bark or other problem features. With this mounted on a screw chuck, I turned a dovetailed spigot to hold in the chuck when it was being hollowed later. I marked the centre, for future reference, with the live centre in the tailstock

2 The wood was indeed soft and easy to turn, but in shaping the underside of the bowl I uncovered a section of very dirty-looking sap-stained wood. As I progressed the turning I hoped to cut through it, but no such luck. The underside of the bowl was discoloured with a very unsightly stain. When I was happy with the shape I sanded it from 120 to 400 grit while wondering what to do with it

3 I'm all in favour of retaining interesting or unusual features in the wood, but only the most optimistic of turners could call this a 'feature'. There could be no doubt it was a blemish and it had to go. From this point on, the original plan went out the window and the first thing to occur to me was to bleach the stains out

4 Following the instructions on the pack, the bleach worked very well and I was left with a relatively stain-free but an incredibly, almost spookily, white surface. It was so unnatural that I couldn't possibly leave it like that

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